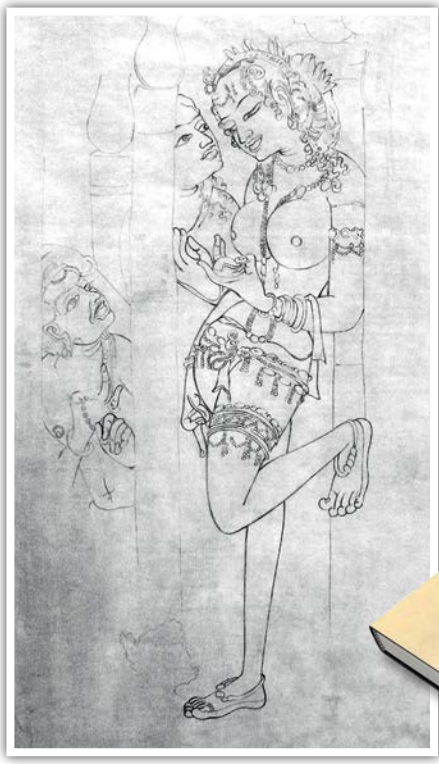
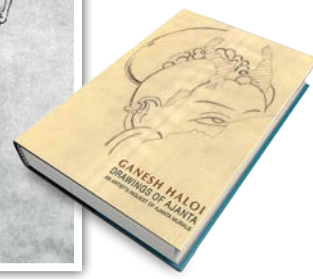


DEFYING TIME
A line drawing by Ganesh Haloi shows Mahamaya, the wife of Suddhodana

DRAWINGS OF AJANTA: An Artist's Inquest of Ajanta Murals
by Ganesh Haloi
ARTISTMINDZ
₹15,000; 370 pages



BOOKS

READING BETWEEN THE LINES

Ganesh Haloi's fine line drawings of the Ajanta murals, done early in his career, have been brought together in a lavish new book

To reimagine the mesmerising beauty of the fragmented murals in the 29 rock-cut caves of Ajanta is like trying to piece together scraps of dreams once we are awake. Years of neglect, unscientific efforts at conservation and copying the murals, vermin, vandalising tourists and moisture from streams seeping in through the rocks have damaged this UNESCO World Heritage Site renowned for its Buddhist religious art. The earliest works date back to second century BCE, while the latest ones were created around 480 CE.

Now, a truly weighty book—in every sense of the term—will help readers visualise the splendours of Ajanta, sans its opulent colours though, through fluid yet precise line drawings of many important sequences. Of this 370-page tome in two parts, all sections from page 119 onwards are devoted to Ganesh Haloi's delicate line drawings of the Ajanta murals in all their glory.

A 15-year-old Haloi had joined the Government College of Art & Craft in Kolkata in 1951, and his gifts were already winning his teachers' admiration. A homeless refugee from what was then East Bengal, he travelled to Bodh Gaya in 1956 on an assignment as Buddha Jayanti was being celebrated that year. In the biting cold, Haloi and his fellow artists had to spend their nights on straw beds in a tent. The artist who had invited them told them how Nandalal Bose in the light of a petromax lamp discovered in Ajanta the mural of a woman grinding chilli peppers, while her companion was rubbing her eyes as the fiery spice had gotten into them (quite unlikely, as there were no chillies in India at the time).

Years later, Haloi concluded that considering the absence of cooking utensils and an oven in the vignette, the woman is actually making sandalwood paste, and her companion is wiping her tears as the king had chosen the path of renunciation.

The Nandalal story fired Haloi's imagination and, as luck would have it, he was employed by the Archaeological Survey of India to make copies of the Ajanta murals. He was there till 1963, when he joined his alma mater as a teacher. While in Ajanta, Haloi made intense studies of the murals, the ingredients of the three-layer ground prepared on the stone walls before applying paint, and of the surroundings of the caves as well. Haloi published his findings—described by the ASI as 'unique'—in 1964 in the *Art in Industry* magazine. Haloi had photographed the murals and the close-by Lenapur village and its inhabitants when he revisited Ajanta in 1968 with his Rolleiflex. In 1995, he projected his photographs of the Ajanta murals and did the pencil (and some brush) drawings, which are a major component of this book.

In keeping with its title, the first part of the elegantly designed book deals with Ganesh Haloi's 'inquest'. It is a valuable document because whenever Haloi points out an earlier misinterpretation of a particular Jataka tale, of gestures or mudras and of facial expressions, he juxtaposes pictorial evidence from various periods to prove his point. The artists often took liberties with the written text of the Jataka tales to make the narrative "more expressive and thought-provoking".

Haloi discovered the 'illusory effect' of architecture in the famous ballet sequence in which the dancer wears a full-sleeved top. He also found three techniques of shading (*vartana*): stippling (*vinduja*), hatching with leaf-like strokes (*patraja*), hatching with long blue lines (*airika*), and ceiling murals imitating wooden beams and rafters. Interestingly, Haloi suggests that these artist-monks were aware of foreshortening (*kshaya briddhi*). In 1968, he thought he had stumbled upon traces of a settlement and a stupa. In 1999-2000 and 2000-2001,

In the book, Haloi, as part of his 'inquest', provides pictorial evidence against earlier misinterpretations

the ASI actually discovered the structural remains of a burnt-brick monastery.

The book begins with Haloi's black-and-white photos of the inhabitants of villages near Ajanta and rock formations of the Sahyadri range, and how these are reflected in the murals (not frescoes, stresses Haloi) in these monasteries. He goes on to describe the importance of lines in the depiction of myriad life forms and the beauty of nature akin to the lyrical descriptions in Kalidasa's *Meghadutam*.

Ultimately, what remain in mind are Ganesh Haloi's drawings that traverse the ethereal and the earthly, the sybaritic and the ascetic, beauty and ugliness, bliss and despair—a holistic view of life. ■

Soumitra Das